

STAGE FOUR • MINDSET, PRODUCTIVITY & HABITS

FIRSTS

FACILITATOR NOTES / SCRIPT

Suggested language for openings, transitions, and prompting discussion

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • Facilitator Notes / Script

Stage Four • Mindset, Productivity & Habits

HOW TO USE THIS SCRIPT

This document is written for a first-time or less confident facilitator who wants actual suggested language, not just a topic list. Everything in quotes is meant to be read close to verbatim, or adapted lightly into your own voice.

This stage's content sits close to real emotional territory — rejection, self-doubt, abandoned habits, genuine hardship. Part 4 in particular is worth reading closely before facilitating, even if you're experienced, since this stage surfaces vulnerability in ways the more mechanical stages (like resume-building) generally don't.

It's organized into four parts: session openings, transitions between FIRSTS, discussion prompting for five specific situations, and tricky moments flagged at specific FIRSTS where participants commonly get uncomfortable or stuck.

Part 1 — Session Openings

Opening Session 1

"Welcome to Stage Four. The first three stages were about clarity and presentation — who you are and how you show up. This stage is about something quieter but just as important: the daily systems that keep you showing up at your best, especially once a job search stretches longer than you'd hoped."

"Nothing today requires special equipment or a polished performance. Some of it is going to feel a little silly — we're going to practice a confidence routine out loud together in a few minutes. That's genuinely fine. The goal is a routine you'll actually use, not one that just looks good on paper."

Opening Session 2

"Last time was about starting habits. Today is about keeping them going — stress management, accountability, and the systems that make a routine survive past the first excited week."

"A quick heads-up: FIRST E12 asks you to lock in a real accountability partner today, in this room, before we finish. Have someone in mind, or be ready to find someone during the session."

Opening Session 3

"Our final session for this stage is different in tone — we shift from internal systems to external differentiation. Five FIRSTS: a side project, volunteer work, a certification, a strategic goal sheet, and a thought leadership post."

"These aren't about doing more for the sake of doing more. Each one is about a genuine signal that's hard to fake — something a resume line alone can't fully capture."

Part 2 — Transitions Between FIRSTS

A few sentences said out loud between exercises and between sessions turns a checklist into a coherent narrative.

FIRST E1 → E2

"You've got a routine for entering a confident state in the moment. A morning ritual does something related but bigger — it sets the tone for your entire day, not just one moment."

FIRST E4 → E5

"Resilience is about recovering well after something goes wrong. Time management is about reducing how often the wrong things get your attention in the first place."

Session 1 → Session 2

"Today was about building routines. Next session is about making them last — what actually keeps a habit alive past the first two weeks, which is usually where they quietly die."

FIRST E12 → E13

"You've got someone checking in on your consistency. Now let's make sure the things you're learning along the way don't just evaporate — that's what a learning log protects."

FIRST E16 → E17

"You now know when you're actually at your best during the day. Let's use some of that energy right now for something that needs real focus: vividly imagining exactly where all of this is heading."

Session 2 → Session 3

"You've built the internal systems — mindset, focus, sustainability. This last session is about the external edge: the specific, hard-to-fake things that make you memorably different from another equally qualified candidate."

FIRST F1 → F2

"A side project shows initiative through what you build. Volunteer work shows character through what you give, often when no one's required you to."

FIRST F4 → F5

"You've just written down where you're actually headed. Let's close by putting a piece of your own thinking out into the world — a small, public marker of the direction you just committed to."

Part 3 — Prompting Discussion in the Moment

Five situations that come up often in this specific stage, with suggested language for each.

Someone feels silly doing the Confidence Routine (E1) out loud

"It's genuinely supposed to feel a little strange the first time — that's normal, not a sign you're doing it wrong. The goal isn't looking cool right now, it's having something real to reach for before a real interview."

A participant admits they've abandoned every habit they've tried (E14 discussion)

"That's an extremely common pattern, not a personal failing. Let's actually look at why — was it the habit itself, or the lack of something to attach it to?" (Redirect toward habit stacking as the structural fix, not more willpower.)

Someone struggles to name 3–5 genuine KPIs (E8) and defaults to vague ones

"Let's get concrete. What's one number that, if it went up this month, would genuinely tell you the search is working?"

The room goes quiet during the Resilience Drill (E4) pair exercise

Give it space — don't rush to fill the silence. If it persists past a minute, offer: "If it's easier, start with what happened, not how it felt. The feelings can come after."

A participant seems reluctant to commit to an Accountability Partner (E12) in the room

"That's okay — it doesn't have to be someone here. But let's at least name who it could be right now, so you're not starting from zero when you leave."

Part 4 — Tricky Moments by FIRST

Four specific FIRSTS where participants commonly encounter genuine emotional weight — and language to navigate each moment with care.

FIRST E4

Resilience Drill

FACILITATOR NOTE

This can surface genuinely painful material — a real rejection, a real disappointment. Keep the paired sharing explicitly scoped to “recent, low-stakes” as instructed, and have a private conversation ready if someone brings something heavier than the exercise was designed for.

FIRST E10

Gratitude Habit

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants may be navigating real hardship where gratitude practice can feel dismissive or forced. Frame it explicitly as additive, not a replacement for acknowledging genuine difficulty: “This doesn't erase what's hard — it just makes sure the hard part isn't the only thing you're tracking.”

FIRST E18

Affirmation Practice

FACILITATOR NOTE

Watch for affirmations that are vague or unearned (“I'm the best candidate for every job”) — gently redirect toward the evidence-based structure the FIRST specifies. An affirmation grounded in something real lands very differently than one that sounds like empty self-help language.

FIRST F2

Volunteer/Impact Experience

FACILITATOR NOTE

Some participants may feel pressure to fabricate passion for a cause they don't genuinely care about, purely for resume purposes. Explicitly discourage this: “This only works if it's real. A forced cause reads as exactly that in an interview.”